

One Step at a Time

On the government's use of the appearance of change to prevent it

Change happens one step at a time, not all at once. But the government has stalled in any forward step by placating the public with a false sense of change that has never been actioned.

This is the closing observation of this report series. It is also the reason the report exists in the form it does — not as a single unified argument delivered in one submission, but as an accumulating record built in sections, cross-referenced, designed so that no single piece can be dismissed without confronting the pattern the pieces form together.

The pattern this report has documented — colonial history producing disability, contaminated land producing disease, regulatory vacuums permitting harm, jurisdictional fractures preventing care, child welfare reproducing dispossession, and now the mandatory ADAP transition proceeding as if none of the preceding context applies — is not a pattern that emerged by accident. It is sustained by a specific governmental practice: the production of the appearance of forward motion in place of forward motion itself.

This closing section names that practice. It names it using the government's own records, the work of Indigenous-led research institutes, and the documented gap between what was committed to and what was delivered. The purpose of the section is not to produce despair. The purpose is to make the mechanism legible, so that future engagement with it can proceed with eyes open.

The architecture of placation

Governments confronted with evidence of serious harm, facing public pressure to act, but unwilling or politically unable to enact the changes that would actually address the harm, have access to a specific administrative toolkit. The toolkit does not require deception. It requires only the substitution of one category of action for another. The categories look similar from the outside. They are structurally distinct.

An announcement is not an action. A consultation is not a decision. A working group is not a policy. A draft framework is not a law. An interim report is not a resolution. A public engagement phase is not a change. Each of these instruments produces a news cycle. Each satisfies the

appearance of responsiveness. Each resets the clock on public demands. Each allows a minister to point to “progress” at a press conference. None of them, on its own, changes what happens to the person waiting for the change.

Over time, the accumulation of these instruments produces a specific effect: advocates become exhausted, the public becomes confused, and the underlying harm continues. The person whose disability benefits are being reclassified on July 1, 2026 does not receive a consultation outcome as compensation for the reclassification. The Mikisew Cree community downstream of the oil sands does not receive a working group as compensation for the cancer. The residential school survivor does not receive a draft framework as compensation for the harm done to them in childhood. And yet, the announcements continue. The consultations proceed. The working groups convene.

This is not a failure of government competence. Governments are highly competent at producing these instruments. What they are not competent at — or not willing to be competent at — is the second step, in which the instrument produces the action it was ostensibly designed to produce.

Exhibit A: the Truth and Reconciliation Commission’s 94 Calls to Action

In June 2015, after six years of hearings and the testimony of more than 6,500 residential school survivors, the Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada released its final report and 94 Calls to Action. The then-federal government committed to implementing all of them.

The Yellowhead Institute, an Indigenous-led research centre at Toronto Metropolitan University, began producing annual status reports in 2019 tracking the Calls’ implementation. Authors Dr. Eva Jewell and Dr. Ian Mosby applied a simple standard: if all aspects of a Call to Action were fulfilled, they considered it complete. Over five years of reporting, they identified a total of five Calls as fully implemented.

In 2023, the Yellowhead Institute reported that zero Calls to Action had been completed over the course of that year. At the pace of progress documented through 2023, the institute projected full implementation of the 94 Calls by the year 2081 — sixty-six years after their release.

The institute then ceased publishing its annual accountability report. The final report stated, in the authors’ own words: “There are limits to how many times you can write a report about how Canada, once again, has failed to make any meaningful progress.”

Subsequent trackers have continued the work. As of September 2025, the Assembly of First Nations’ TRC Report Card and the Indigenous Watchdog tracker jointly identify 13 Calls to Action as fully completed. That is 13 of 94, ten years after the Calls were released. No new Calls were completed in the 2024–2025 reporting year.

Dr. Eva Jewell, in her 2024 reflection for the Yellowhead Institute, summarized the pattern: “Symbolic gestures divorced from structural accountability do not constitute reconciliation.” A 2025 Yellowhead Institute review of the seven healthcare-specific Calls (Calls 18 through 24, addressed in Section 14 of this report) concluded — after a year-long environmental scan of federal, provincial, and territorial action between April 2024 and April 2025 — “limited progress across all three strands” of meaningful reconciliation.

Ten years. 94 Calls. 13 completed. A projected completion date beyond the lifespan of most residential school survivors still living. These are not findings from an advocacy organization. They are findings from Indigenous-led research institutions applying straightforward implementation standards to government-promised commitments. The government’s response has been the continued production of announcements, reports, and engagement processes.

*There are limits to how many times you can write a report about how Canada, once again, has failed to make any meaningful progress. —
Yellowhead Institute, final accountability report, 2023*

Exhibit B: the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples

The United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (UNDRIP) was adopted by the UN General Assembly in 2007. Canada initially voted against adoption. Canada subsequently reversed position in 2010. The federal United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples Act received Royal Assent in June 2021, committing Canada to align its laws with UNDRIP.

UNDRIP Article 21 guarantees the right of Indigenous peoples “without discrimination, to the improvement of their economic and social conditions, including, inter alia, in the areas of education, employment, vocational training and retraining, housing, sanitation, health and social security.” Article 23 affirms the right of Indigenous peoples to “determine and develop priorities and strategies for exercising their right to development,” and specifically “to be actively involved in developing and determining health, housing and other economic and social programmes affecting them.”

The ADAP transition, which will change the disability benefits of approximately 79,290 Albertans — a significant portion of whom are Indigenous — was designed and rolled out without Indigenous consultation meeting UNDRIP’s free, prior, and informed consent standard. The Alberta government has publicly stated that it does not consider itself bound by the federal UNDRIP legislation. The federal government, which is bound, has not intervened.

The gap between the passage of UNDRIP legislation and its practical application is an example of the placation pattern at a structural scale. The passage of the legislation produced an extensive news cycle. International observers characterized the passage as meaningful

reconciliation progress. Four years later, at the provincial level where the majority of daily contact with Indigenous peoples occurs — health, education, child welfare, policing, disability benefits — the legislation's operational effect has been negligible. The announcement occurred. The action has not.

Exhibit C: the 231 Calls for Justice

In June 2019, the National Inquiry into Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women and Girls released its final report, containing 231 Calls for Justice. The report characterized the violence documented as a “race-based genocide.”

Implementation tracking of the 231 Calls for Justice has been conducted by the Native Women's Association of Canada, the Assembly of First Nations, and Indigenous Watchdog. Those trackers have consistently documented that the majority of the Calls for Justice remain not started or in progress, six years after their release. The federal National Action Plan, released in 2021 in response to the Calls for Justice, has itself been characterized by Indigenous organizations as insufficient and under-resourced relative to the scale of the harm it was intended to address.

As with the TRC Calls to Action, the response has taken the form of the instruments of placation rather than the instruments of action: federal strategy documents, working tables, funded initiatives of individually modest scope, and repeated announcements of renewed commitment. The structural drivers of the violence — child welfare over-apprehension, housing crisis, policing failures, justice system discrimination — continue at approximately the rates documented at the time of the Inquiry's publication.

Exhibit D: the ADAP engagement process itself

The placation pattern is not only historical. It is operating in real time, on the file this report series was constructed to address.

The provincial government of Alberta, in announcing the transition from AISH to ADAP, characterized the process as the product of public engagement. The ADAP engagement program has received submissions, held consultations, and produced communication materials describing the outcomes of public input. Those materials have been cited in political communications as evidence that the transition is responsive to the needs of the affected population.

The documented reality is different. AISH recipients across the province have reported, in formal submissions to the ADAP engagement inbox, to Alberta Members of the Legislative Assembly, to municipal councils, to federal Members of Parliament, to the Alberta Ombudsman, to the UN Special Rapporteur on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities, and to the HUMA Standing Committee of the House of Commons, that the ADAP transition does not reflect their

needs or consent. The submissions have, in the majority of documented cases, received no substantive response beyond acknowledgment of receipt. The transition is proceeding. The July 1, 2026 implementation date has not moved.

The engagement was the announcement. The consultation was the placation. The transition is the action — but the action is not the action the engagement appeared to describe. It is a separate action, moving on its own schedule, unchanged by the engagement whose outcomes it invokes.

This is the same pattern visible in the TRC, UNDRIP, and MMIWG files. The only difference is proximity. Indigenous Albertans and their non-Indigenous neighbours being moved from AISH to ADAP on July 1, 2026 are experiencing the placation pattern not as a matter of historical record but as a current condition of their lives.

Why the pattern works

The architecture of placation succeeds because it exploits specific features of public attention and political accountability.

First, announcements compress well into news cycles. Implementation does not. A minister announcing a new strategy on a Tuesday will receive measured coverage on Wednesday; the question of whether the strategy's implementation milestone was met thirty-six months later will, in most cases, not receive coverage at all. The information asymmetry between announcement and delivery is structural, not accidental.

Second, advocates are finite. The communities carrying the burden of documenting harm are, by definition, the communities already most affected by the harm. Requiring those communities to also produce the audit of implementation is a form of compounded extraction. Yellowhead Institute's decision to cease publishing its annual TRC accountability report is not a failure of Indigenous scholarship. It is the reasonable conclusion of a finite group of researchers observing that the production of yet another report documenting yet another year of non-implementation had ceased to produce change.

Third, the public cannot easily distinguish between active change and the appearance of active change. Most members of the general public, presented with a headline about a new reconciliation initiative or a new disability engagement process, have no practical means of determining whether the initiative has produced results. The default assumption is that announcements correspond to actions. That assumption is, in the placation pattern, structurally incorrect.

Fourth, the timelines work against the public. Major policy cycles take years. Elections occur on shorter schedules. The government that announces an initiative is frequently not the government that would be responsible for its delivery. Accountability fragments across mandates, administrations, and institutional memories.

The counter-practice: one step at a time

The response to the architecture of placation cannot be, and is not, the demand for comprehensive change delivered in a single decisive stroke. That demand is precisely the posture the placation pattern is designed to produce, because comprehensive demands can be met with comprehensive announcements, which reset the cycle.

The response, instead, is incremental, documentary, cumulative, and patient. Every section of this report is a step. Every formal submission is a step. Every municipal council motion is a step. Every individual story entered into the record is a step. Every published source cited by its full title and author is a step. Every cross-referenced connection between the fiscal, medical, colonial, and environmental dimensions of the ADAP transition is a step.

No individual step in this report series will produce the reversal of the July 1, 2026 transition. That is not what the steps are for. The steps are for the permanent record. They are for the accumulation of evidence that cannot be withdrawn, unpublished, or unsaid. They are for the moment when a future government, under different political conditions, chooses to examine the policy legacy of the current one and finds that the documentary record is already constructed, already cited, already structured for review.

The steps are also for the communities presently affected. Every person who encounters this report — in full, in part, in plain-language version, or in excerpted form — and recognizes their own experience in it receives one thing the placation architecture is specifically designed to prevent: confirmation that they are not alone, that what they are experiencing is documented, and that the documentation is available to them in their own time.

This is not a small thing. Isolation is not an accidental feature of the placation architecture. It is a functional feature. A population that believes itself to be facing an individual difficulty rather than a structural pattern will advocate as individuals. A population that recognizes the structural pattern will advocate as a structure. The first kind of advocacy is manageable. The second kind is not.

You are not alone. We stand together.

The closing of this series

This report has been constructed in sixteen sections because the pattern it documents has sixteen dimensions, and each dimension has its own evidentiary base, its own history, its own Alberta-specific and pan-Canadian manifestations, and its own bearing on the July 1, 2026 ADAP transition.

The sections do not stand alone. They are cross-referenced to one another, to the fiscal hypocrisy analysis developed in the broader campaign materials, to the Charter and UNDRIP analysis that will follow, and to the community-level organizing already underway across

Edmonton, Calgary, Lethbridge, Red Deer, Claresholm, Camrose, Medicine Hat, Rocky Mountain House, and the additional municipalities joining the coalition each week.

The purpose of constructing this record is not to produce a single document that forces immediate change. The purpose is to contribute to an accumulating weight of evidence that, at a moment that cannot be fully predicted in advance, becomes structurally impossible to continue to ignore. That moment may arrive on July 1, 2026. It may arrive in the fall of 2026, as the transition produces its documented first wave of harm. It may arrive in the 2027 provincial election cycle. It may arrive later. What the documentation ensures is that when it arrives, the record is already built.

Until that moment: one step at a time. Every submission. Every council. Every conversation. Every source cited in full. Every name entered into the permanent record of what a government knew, and when, and what it chose to do about it.

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